women and child development only in 2017. The decision to make Mission Shakti an independent department with a dedicated budget was taken in 2021. With increased powers and a budget of Rs 2,100 crore, the MS department is now empowered to handle funds and make independent policies. The other reason was to expand the ambit of SHGs and gradually nudge them into the SME (small and medium-sized enterprises) category after helping them expand operations. To this end, SHGs are being encouraged to form block level federations which, as larger entities, are a step closer to the goal. Producer groups of 50 members—with a one-time grant of Rs 2.04 lakh—have been formed to foster an entrepreneurial spirit. The producer groups that do well coalesce and proceed to bigger platforms—becoming producer companies—with bigger market potential. The Odisha government is giving Rs 61.5 lakh in phases to each such company that evolves and enters the SME sector. From being an SHG member to becoming an established entrepreneur—this is the dream MS is weaving for its members.

"Mission Shakti enables women to facilitate economic activities from the supplier's point (production end) to the user's point (consumption end). This improves the supply chain, while the involvement of SHGs reduces the transaction cost," says economist Asit Mohanty. "In Odisha, credit penetration by banks is very low. Small loans to SHGs will improve that. Therefore, banks in Odisha should take MS as an opportunity," he adds.

One key factor that has helped MS groups thrive is healthy loan behaviour. For timely repayment of loans, the government gives interest subvention (subsidised interest rates). In fact, it rewards the repayment of loans for up to Rs 3,00,000 with zero per cent interest. In the last fiscal, Rs 162 crore was spent towards this; this year, Rs 200 crore is budgeted for interest subvention of SHGs. Out of the 622,000 SHGs, most are regular about repayment. "The principal imperative to repayment is helping the group survive. The group is everything to us—providing strength and helping stand on our own two feet, and opening a window to a world of possibilities," says Basanti Sahoo of Delang block federation. Her original team of 10 poor women collected paddy and other farm produce from farmers and sold them at the market, bypassing the exploitative middlemen. In 2002, the women earned Rs 2,500 a month. Today, each of the 80 women working in Basanti's federation gets a monthly sal-





NEW HORIZONS
CM Naveen Patnaik with SHG members in Bhubaneswar; two members add a dash of glam while out to read electricity meters

Employment for women under MS is up, with many opting for jobs that break gender stereotypes. Like being banking agents or PDS dealers